SMOKED RABBIT WITH CRANBERRY BEANS AND DRIED STRAWBERRIES

serves 4

We often think of cranberry beans as tan and speckled with pink, but there is a variety of heirloom cranberry beans that are deep-red before they are cooked. (You can find the seeds from a number of vendors online and can occasionally find the beans from smaller vendors. You can, of course, substitute another bean if you prefer.)

This dish takes several hours over a couple of days to pull together because you must brine, smoke, braise, and sauté the rabbit and soak and cook the beans. The results, however, are worth it, because the rabbit is unbelievably flavorful. Dehydrated strawberries (or store-bought dried strawberries) provide a sweet-and-sour exclamation point to the dish.

You can make all of the components a day in advance and bring them together quickly as you would a pasta dish right before serving.

You will need a smoker for this recipe, or you can rig a charcoal or gas grill to work as a smoker and cook the rabbit low and slow. (See Smoking Food on a Grill, page 69, for the method.)

- 2 cups small strawberries, cut into ⅛-inch-thick slices, or ¼ cup (4 ounces) dried sliced strawberries
- 1 whole rabbit (2½ pounds)
- Fine sea salt
- 1 cup maple syrup, plus more as needed
- 4 (8-inch) pieces white pine (see Conifers, page 22)
- Ground sumac
- 1 cup dried True Cranberry beans or other cranberry beans, soaked overnight and drained
- 3 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 5 whole ramps, wild onions, or scallions, cut crosswise into 1-inch pieces
- 1 cup packed dandelion leaves, coarsely chopped

If starting with fresh strawberries, arrange them on the tray of a dehydrator and dehydrate for 6 to 12 hours, until dry but still chewy. (Alternatively, preheat an oven to 170°F or your oven's lowest setting. Arrange the sliced berries on a rack set over a baking sheet and bake, checking them after 4 hours and once every 30 minutes after that until they are dry but pliable and chewy.)

In a bowl or container large enough to hold the rabbit with brine, stir together 4 cups room temperature water, ¾ cup plus 2 tablespoons salt, and the maple syrup until the salt dissolves. Stir in 12 more cups water. Submerge the rabbit and add half the white pine. Refrigerate overnight.

The next day, rinse the rabbit well and rub it all over with sumac. Discard the brine.

Preheat a smoker to 240°F (or if you don't have a smoker, see Smoking Food on a Grill, page 69).

Smoke the rabbit according to the manufacturer's instructions for 1½ hours. Flip and smoke for another 1½ hours and then remove from the smoker. (The rabbit's internal temperature should register at least 165°F on an instant-read thermometer when inserted into the thickest part of the meat, away from the bone.)

Transfer to a cutting board and cut the smoked rabbit into serving pieces (legs, thighs, and saddle), then arrange in a Dutch oven. Add water to just barely cover and the remaining white pine. Bring the water to a simmer over medium heat, then reduce the heat to medium-low, cover, and gently simmer for about 1½ hours, or until the rabbit is very tender and falling off the bone.

Meanwhile, rinse the beans well and transfer to a pot. Add water to cover by 2 inches and bring to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to medium-low, partially cover, and simmer for 40 minutes to 1 hour 15 minutes, until the beans are tender but not overcooked. Drain, then spread out on a baking sheet to cool. Season with salt.

Uncover the rabbit and discard the white pine. Reserving 1 cup of the cooking liquid, drain the rabbit. Pull the rabbit meat off the bones.

In a large cast-iron skillet, heat the oil over medium-high heat until shimmering. Add the smoked and braised rabbit meat and sear for about 5 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the edges of the meat start to brown and crisp a bit. Add the ramps and cook for 2 to 3 minutes, until wilted and nearly tender. Add the cooled cooked beans with ½ cup of the rabbit cooking liquid and stir gently to not break the beans. Taste and season with salt, maple syrup, and sumac.

Reduce the heat to low and cook just until you see steam rising from the skillet, then add most of the dried strawberries and the chopped dandelion leaves and stir gently to incorporate.

Transfer to a serving bowl. Garnish with the remaining dried strawberries and serve.